UNIT 2 · CHAPTER 7 · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Union Breaks

The shooting war begins — and a fight to save the Union becomes a fight to end slavery. 1861–1863.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The shooting war begins — and a fight to save the Union becomes a fight to end slavery. 1861–1863.

How did a war to preserve the Union become a war to end slavery?

The First Shots

APRIL 1861

Lincoln had barely taken office when it came. South Carolina demanded the surrender of Fort Sumter, a federal fort in Charleston Harbor. When Lincoln sent only food, the Confederates opened fire. After 34 hours of bombardment, the fort surrendered.

No one was killed in the shelling — but the war was on. Lincoln called for 75,000 volunteers, and four more states, including Virginia, left the Union rather than fight the South. The line was drawn.

The Union Breaks

SPRING 1861

Eleven states leave; four slave states stay; the border will help decide the war.

The divided nation in 1861: the Confederate states (ember), the free Union states (slate), and the four border slave states that stayed in the Union (gold). · Map © ShadowDog Digital Studios

“On to Richmond”

JULY 1861

Both sides expected a short, glorious war — over by Christmas. When the armies met at Bull Run in Virginia, Washington civilians rode out with picnic baskets to watch.

The watching stopped fast. The Union army broke and fled back to Washington in a panic. The lesson was brutal and clear: this war would be long, and it would be bloody.

A Scale No One Imagined

THE ARITHMETIC OF LOSS

At Shiloh in 1862, more Americans fell in two days than in all the nation's earlier wars combined. At Antietam that September came the bloodiest single day in American history.

New rifled weapons met old shoulder-to-shoulder tactics, and the result was slaughter. A country that had expected a quick, romantic war was learning the true price of this one.

Iron Against Wood

AT SEA

The Union strategy was to strangle the South — a naval blockade to choke off its trade and cotton. The South answered with a new weapon.

In March 1862 the ironclad Virginia (built from the captured Merrimack) fought the Union's Monitor to a draw off the Virginia coast. Neither could sink the other — and in a single afternoon, every wooden warship on earth became obsolete.

A War for Freedom

JANUARY 1, 1863

For two years Lincoln had called it a war to save the Union. Antietam gave him the victory he needed to change that. On New Year's Day 1863, the Emancipation Proclamation declared the enslaved in rebel states “forever free.”

It freed few people the day it was signed and exempted the loyal border states. But it transformed the war's meaning: Union armies were now armies of liberation, and no European power would dare side with slavery.

FREDERICK DOUGLASS · 1863

Once let the Black man get upon his person the brass letters U.S.; let him get an eagle on his button, and a musket on his shoulder — and there is no power on earth which can deny that he has earned the right to citizenship.

Their Own Freedom

MEN IN BLUE

The Proclamation did something else: it let Black men enlist. Nearly 200,000 would serve in the United States Colored Troops — many of them formerly enslaved, now fighting in uniform for their own liberty.

At Fort Wagner in July 1863, the 54th Massachusetts charged a fortified Confederate position against hopeless odds. They were cut down in numbers — but their courage silenced doubters across the North and proved Black soldiers would fight and die for the Union.

The War Behind the Lines

THE HOME FRONT

The war strained both societies to the breaking point. In July 1863 the New York City Draft Riots erupted: white mobs, enraged that the rich could buy their way out of the draft, turned their fury on the city's Black residents in the deadliest riot in American history to that point.

Women ran farms and factories, served as spies, and nursed the wounded by the thousands — figures like Clara Barton — while prison camps like Andersonville showed how merciless this war had become. By 1863, the war had changed into something total.

Twelve Fronts

YOUR TURN

This chapter runs from the first shot to the turn toward freedom — on battlefields, at sea, and on the home front. Pick a front and investigate it as a historian.